

FEDERAL LAUNCH KIT · CERTIFICATIONS

VOSB / SDVOSB CVE Application Guide.

INSIDE THIS MANUAL ↓

- ✓ **Eligibility check** · VOSB and SDVOSB rules side by side
- ✓ **Document pack** · Ten files VetCert expects, by source
- ✓ **VetCert walkthrough** · Nine steps from login to certified
- ✓ **Rejection fixes** · Six common denials and how to recover

THE FOUR-TOOL SYSTEM

FREE · LETTER PDF

01

Eligibility check

VOSB and SDVOSB rules side by side

02

Document pack

Ten files VetCert expects, by source

03

VetCert walkthrough

Nine steps from login to certified

04

Rejection fixes

Six common denials and how to recover

[/ INSIDE THIS GUIDE](#)

Inside this guide.

PART ONE • ELIGIBILITY + PAPERWORK

V01	Why CVE certification matters \$28.6B in annual SDVOSB spend. The market math behind the application.	p. 04
V02	Eligibility checklist Eight conditions that decide whether VetCert says yes.	p. 05
V03	Documents required Ten files VetCert wants, where to source each one.	p. 06
V04	Pre-application prep Four cleanups to run before you open vetcert.va.gov.	p. 07

PART TWO • APPLY + RECOVER

V05	VetCert application walkthrough Nine steps in the order the system asks for them.	p. 09
V06	Common rejection reasons Six denial patterns with the exact fix for each.	p. 10
V07	After you're certified Set-aside SAM.gov filters, three-year recert calendar.	p. 11
V08	Where to go next Resources, contacts, and the next move once the letter lands.	p. 12



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A LETTER TO THE OPERATOR

VOSB and SDVOSB are the only set-asides worth the paperwork for veteran founders.

I work with a lot of veteran-owned firms. Most of them know they qualify for SDVOSB. Maybe half have actually filed. The other half got scared off by the CVE process, or filed once, got denied, and never went back.

The application isn't actually hard. VetCert processes the average clean file in about 12 days now, down from 60+ days back in 2023. The slow ones are slow for one reason: the operating agreement, the SAM.gov record, and the DD-214 don't tell the same story about who runs the company.

This guide is the checklist I run with every veteran founder before they submit. Eligibility on one page, the document pack on the next, the nine VetCert steps after that, and the six denial patterns we keep seeing. If you've already been denied once, jump to page 10 and find your pattern.

When you're ready to file, book a 30-minute call. We'll walk your docs together and catch the mismatches before VetCert does.

A. Schuler

30 MIN · NO PITCH

Book a B2G Audit call

<https://meetings-na2.hubspot.com/american/intro-call>

Book the call →

\$28.6B a year flows through SDVOSB set-asides.

The VA and DoD spend roughly \$28.6 billion a year on contracts reserved for Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned Small Businesses. The VA has a 15% SDVOSB goal — the most aggressive set-aside target of any federal agency. Sole-source awards up to \$5 million are on the table for SDVOSBs, and up to \$7 million for manufacturing.

The price of admission is one certification: VetCert at vetcert.va.gov. The next four pages cover who qualifies, what to send, and how to stage the file so the examiner approves it the first time.

PART ONE • ELIGIBILITY + PAPERWORK

Why CVE Certification Matters

VOSB and SDVOSB are the two veteran set-asides recognized across the federal government. SDVOSB is the bigger market by a wide margin — and the only one with a hard agency-level goal attached to it.

\$28.6B
 SDVOSB ANNUAL SPEND
 FY2025 federal market
 12 days
 VETCERT PROCESSING
 Average vs. 60+ days in 2023
 3 years
 CERTIFICATION PERIOD
 Then full recertification

WHAT YOU UNLOCK

- VA 15% goal.** The Department of Veterans Affairs is required to award at least 15% of contract dollars to SDVOSBs. No other agency comes close.
- Sole-source awards.** Contracting officers can award SDVOSBs directly up to \$5M (services) or \$7M (manufacturing) without competition.
- Set-aside competitions.** Federal-wide SDVOSB-only competitions where you're bidding against a much smaller, more focused field.

VOSB vs SDVOSB — what’s the difference

CATEGORY	VOSB	SDVOSB
Veteran status	Honorable discharge from any branch	Honorable discharge + VA-rated service-connected disability (any rating, even 0%)
Set-aside scope	Primarily VA contracting	All federal agencies
Annual spend	Roughly \$1B at the VA	\$28.6B federal-wide
Sole-source ceiling	Limited	\$5M services / \$7M manufacturing
Application	Same VetCert portal	Same VetCert portal + VA disability letter

The practical answer: if you have a service-connected disability rating, apply as SDVOSB. The paperwork is nearly identical and the market is roughly 28× larger.

PART ONE • ELIGIBILITY + PAPERWORK

Eligibility Checklist

VetCert verifies every one of these conditions. Miss one and the application gets denied, not delayed. Walk this checklist before you start the file.

Veteran-Owned Small Business (VOSB)

All of the following must be true:

✓	REQUIREMENT	WHAT VETCERT CHECKS
☐	51%+ unconditionally owned by one or more veterans (or surviving spouses)	Stock ledger, ownership certificates, operating agreement
☐	Management and daily operations controlled by a veteran	Operating agreement signature authority, organizational chart
☐	Veteran holds the highest officer position — President, CEO, or Managing Member	Title on the SAM.gov record, articles of organization, payroll records
☐	Business qualifies as 'small' under SBA size standards for your primary NAICS	3-year average revenue or employee count vs. the NAICS threshold
☐	Business is registered in SAM.gov and in good standing	Active SAM record, no exclusions, name and address match the application

Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned (SDVOSB) — adds three more

✓	REQUIREMENT	WHAT VETCERT CHECKS
☐	Veteran has a service-connected disability rated by the VA — any rating, even 0%	Current VA Rating Letter from VA Benefits portal
☐	VA disability letter or DD-214 with service connection documentation available	Both documents on file, names and dates match
☐	Veteran controls strategic policy decisions AND daily operations	Operating agreement clauses, voting rights, signature authority

FIELD TIP

If your operating agreement gives non-veteran partners veto rights over major decisions, you don't meet the control test even if you own 51%. Amend the agreement before you submit — see the rejection-fixes page for the exact language to change.

PART ONE • ELIGIBILITY + PAPERWORK

Documents Required for VetCert

Ten files. Source each one before you start the application — VetCert's session timeout will burn you if you're hunting for documents mid-upload.

DOCUMENT	SOURCE	WHY VETCERT NEEDS IT
DD-214 (Member 4 copy)	National Archives or VA eBenefits	Proves veteran status and characterization of discharge
VA Rating Letter (SDVOSB only)	VA Benefits portal or regional office	Proves service-connected disability rating
Articles of Incorporation / Organization	State business registry or original attorney filing	Proves business structure and ownership %
Operating Agreement / Bylaws	Original company formation documents	Shows veteran's voting rights and management control
Ownership certificates or stock ledger	Corporate records	Documents who owns what percentage
Financial statements (2 years)	Your accountant or QuickBooks	Proves size and financial health
Tax returns (3 years, if applicable)	IRS or your CPA	Verifies revenue for size-standard purposes
Lease or mortgage for business address	Landlord agreement or mortgage statement	Proves principal place of business
Payroll records	Your payroll provider — ADP, Gusto, etc.	Shows who works there and in what capacity
SAM.gov registration printout	sam.gov entity record	Shows active registration matching the application

FILE-NAMING DISCIPLINE

Name every file the way an examiner will scan it: `DD214_Smith_John.pdf`, `VA_Rating_Letter_Smith_2026.pdf`, `Operating_Agreement_Acme_LLC_v3.pdf`. Vague names like `Document1.pdf` add review days because the examiner has to open every file to figure out what it is.

PART ONE • ELIGIBILITY + PAPERWORK

Pre-Application Prep

Four cleanups to run before you log into VetCert. Each one prevents a specific rejection pattern we cover on page 10.

1. Reconcile [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) to your articles

Open your [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) entity record next to your articles of incorporation. Compare:

- Legal business name — punctuation, LLC vs L.L.C., commas — all match exactly
- Physical address — same suite number, same ZIP+4
- Primary NAICS code — the one you'll claim for size-standard purposes
- Owner names — same legal name on both records

If anything drifts, update [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) first. VetCert pulls live from SAM, and a mismatch is the single fastest path to a hold.

2. Audit the operating agreement for control language

Open the operating agreement and look for clauses that limit the veteran owner's authority:

- 'Unanimous consent required for...' — kills the control test if veteran isn't the only voter
- 'Right of first refusal' on the veteran's stake — courts can read this as conditional ownership
- 'Quorum requires both members' — same problem
- 'Tie-breaker vote goes to...' anyone other than the veteran

If you find any of these, amend before you submit. The fix is usually a one-page amendment naming the veteran as Managing Member with sole authority over enumerated decisions.

3. Confirm the size standard

Look up your primary NAICS code at sba.gov/size-standards. The standard is either revenue-based (3-year average) or employee-based (12-month average). Calculate yours against the current threshold.

If you're within 10% of the ceiling, attach a one-page memo to the application explaining the calculation. Examiners appreciate the transparency and it heads off a follow-up question.

4. Pull the VA Rating Letter fresh

SDVOSB applicants only. Log into the VA Benefits portal and download a current rating letter — dated within the last 12 months. Old letters get bounced back as 'not current' even when the underlying rating hasn't changed.

TIME ESTIMATE

All four cleanups together: about **4 to 6 hours** if your records are organized, a full day if they're not. Do this before you open vetcert.va.gov, not after.

PART TWO • APPLY + RECOVER

Nine steps inside VetCert. Then the cleanup.

The application itself takes about two hours once your documents are sourced and labeled. The order matters — VetCert won't let you skip ahead, and the system times out after 30 minutes of inactivity.

After you submit, the examiner usually comes back with one or two clarifying questions inside the first week. Answer them in 48 hours and you'll see a decision in roughly 12 days. Delay past 10 business days and the file goes to the bottom of the queue.

PART TWO • APPLY + RECOVER

VetCert Application — Step by Step

Nine steps in the order VetCert asks for them. Do them in one or two sittings — saving and resuming is supported but each resume burns a few minutes on re-authentication.

#	STEP	WATCH OUT FOR
1	Create an account at vetcert.va.gov using your Login.gov credentials — same ones as SAM.gov.	If your Login.gov has MFA via authenticator app, have your phone ready.
2	Start a new application. Select SDVOSB or VOSB based on whether you have a VA disability rating.	You can apply for both in one filing if you qualify. Don't file two separate applications.
3	Complete the Owner Profile. Answer every question — partial answers cause processing delays.	The 'Other Business Interests' question matters. Disclose every entity where you hold 10%+ ownership.
4	Complete the Business Profile — business description, NAICS codes, size certification.	NAICS list should match SAM.gov. Primary NAICS drives the size-standard test.
5	Upload all required documents. File names must be clear — e.g., <code>DD214_Smith_John.pdf</code> .	50 MB per file ceiling. PDFs are preferred; the system accepts DOCX but converts them.
6	Submit and note your application reference number.	Screenshot the confirmation. The reference number is the only way customer service can pull your file.
7	VA examiner reviews and may request additional documentation. Respond within 10 business days .	Past 10 days the file goes back to the queue — adds two to three weeks.
8	Approval notice arrives by email. Print and save the certification letter.	The PDF letter is your proof of certification — attach it to every proposal cover letter for the first year.
9	Verify your certification appears in SAM.gov — usually syncs within 48 hours.	If it doesn't show after 72 hours, open a Federal Service Desk ticket at fsd.gov with the certification letter attached.

TIMELINE

Day 0: Submit. **Day 1–5:** Examiner assignment + first review. **Day 5–10:** Clarification request, if any. **Day 10–14:** Decision. **Day 14–16:** SAM.gov sync. Plan for a full month from submit to first set-aside bid.

PART TWO • APPLY + RECOVER

Common Rejection Reasons & Fixes

Six denial patterns make up roughly 80% of VetCert rejections. Each one has a clean fix — most can be resolved without restarting the application.

REJECTION REASON	FIX
Veteran not in day-to-day management control	Document specific daily decisions the veteran makes — payroll approval, contract signature, hiring authority. Adjust the title on payroll records if needed so it matches the operating agreement.
Unconditional ownership not proven	Remove any clauses that restrict the veteran's ability to sell or transfer ownership. 'Right of first refusal' clauses are the most common culprit and need to be amended out.
Disability rating letter not current	Request an updated letter from VA Benefits at va.gov/decision-reviews . Letters dated within the last 12 months are accepted without question.
Operating agreement gives non-veteran veto rights	Amend the operating agreement so all major decisions — capital calls, dissolution, new members — flow through the veteran owner. The fix is usually a one-page amendment.
Business address doesn't match SAM.gov	Update SAM.gov before reapplying. Addresses must match exactly — same suite number, same ZIP+4. Wait 24 hours for SAM to refresh before you resubmit to VetCert.
Multiple owners dilute veteran control	Ensure the veteran's combined ownership is unambiguously 51%+. If two veterans own 30% and 25%, that's fine. If one veteran owns 51% and a non-veteran owns 49% with veto rights, that's a denial.

IF YOU'RE DENIED

You have **30 days** to file an appeal at the SBA Office of Hearings and Appeals, but the faster path is to fix the underlying issue and reapply. Reapplications go through the same queue as new files — no penalty, no delay.

PART TWO • APPLY + RECOVER

After You're Certified

The certification letter is the start of the work, not the end. Here's the 90-day playbook once the approval lands.

Week one — update every system

- **SAM.gov.** Confirm the SDVOSB or VOSB flag appears on your entity record. If it's missing after 72 hours, open a Federal Service Desk ticket.
- **Capability statement.** Add the certification badge to the header. Update the certifications section with the certification number and date.
- **DSBS profile.** Update the Dynamic Small Business Search profile at dsbs.sba.gov so contracting officers can find you in their searches.
- **Email signature.** Add 'SDVOSB Certified' under your name. Contracting officers notice.

Week two to four — start hunting set-asides

Go to sam.gov/opportunities and filter on:

- **Set-Aside Type:** SDVOSB Set-Aside or SDVOSB Sole Source
- **NAICS:** your primary code
- **Posted Date:** last 30 days

Start with sources sought notices in your NAICS. These are 6 to 18 months ahead of the actual solicitation and let you shape the requirements before the RFP drops.

Month two to three — the introduction round

Identify the 10 contracting officers most active in your NAICS at agencies with strong SDVOSB programs — VA, Army Corps of Engineers, GSA. Send each one your capability statement with a one-paragraph email introducing the new certification. No ask, no meeting request. Just on the record.

THREE-YEAR RECERTIFICATION CALENDAR

Year 1. File the full application, build your set-aside pipeline.

Year 2. Track any ownership, control, or size-standard changes. Document them as they happen.

Month 30. Begin the recertification process — same VetCert portal, lighter paperwork if nothing material has changed.

Month 36. Recertification must be complete or the SDVOSB flag drops from SAM.gov automatically.

PART TWO • APPLY + RECOVER

Where to Go Next

The official sources, the support lines, and the next pieces of the Federal Launch Kit that pair with this guide.

Official portals

RESOURCE	WHAT IT'S FOR
vetcert.va.gov	Apply, check status, manage recertification
sam.gov	Entity registration, set-aside opportunity search
va.gov/osdbu	VA Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization — events, mentor matching
sba.gov/size-standards	Current size thresholds by NAICS
dsbs.sba.gov	Dynamic Small Business Search — make yourself findable to contracting officers
va.gov/decision-reviews	Request a current VA rating letter

Support contacts

- **VetCert Help Desk** — built into vetcert.va.gov under the help menu. Average response 2 business days.
- **VA OSDBU Help Desk** — 866-584-2344. Best for eligibility questions before you apply.
- **Federal Service Desk** — fsd.gov. For [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) sync issues after certification.

What pairs with this guide

SAM.gov Annual Renewal Kit. Your VOSB / SDVOSB certification flag rides on your SAM record. Keep the underlying registration current or the certification effectively goes dark.

Capability Statement Template. Add the SDVOSB badge to the header, list the certification number in the corner. We've got a one-page template designed for veteran-owned firms.

Pre-Solicitation Playbook. The set-aside opportunities you're now eligible for show up as sources sought notices 6 to 18 months before the RFP. The playbook covers how to position there.

When you're ready to file or you've been denied and want a second pair of eyes on the application — book a 30-minute call. We'll walk the file together.

WHAT'S NEXT

Stop **guessing** whether you'll qualify.

CapturePilot runs a 30-minute eligibility review for every veteran founder before they file with VetCert. We walk your operating agreement, your SAM.gov record, and your document pack together — the same audit we run for the firms whose applications get approved on the first pass. No card required, no pitch.

Get the full Federal Launch Kit

[HTTPS://WWW.CAPTUREPILOT.COM/STARTUP-PACK](https://www.capturepilot.com/startup-pack)